students. Hooda has promised to scrap the last one if he comes to power.

But the Congress satrap is also staring at a lot of intra-party factionalism. Most of his rivals have already joined the BJP, including his former cabinet colleagues Kiran Chaudhary, Venod Sharma and Savitri Jindal. Others, like his cousin Chaudhary Birender Singh, may have returned to the Congress after spending a decade in the BJP, but are still sulking, as are Captain Ajay Yadav and Randeep Singh Surjewala. It has yet to be seen if the Congress high command gives him a free hand to run the campaign and select candidates.

Saini, meanwhile, has embarked on corrective measures with gusto. The ball has been set rolling for recruitment to 50,000 state government jobs. Several social welfare schemes, like the Mukhyamantri Kisan Evam Khetihar Mazdoor Jeevan Suraksha Yojana, Dr B R Ambedkar Awas Navinikarn Yojana, Mukhyamantri Gramin Awas Yojana, are being fine-tuned. The bulk of their beneficiaries, Haryana BJP leaders say, are Dalits or OBCs.

A RESURGENT HOODA IS HOPING TO BUILD ON THE MOMENTUM OF THE LOK SABHA POLLS, WHERE THE CONGRESS WON 5 OUT OF 10 SEATS

Partymen have also been instructed to begin "Mission 100" (number of days to the assembly polls) and go on door-to-door outreach campaigns. Khattar has said his partymen will reach out to (Dalit) families "to expose Congress falsehoods" (of the BJP doing away with reservations if it came to power at the Centre) and "misrule" which saw "atrocities on Dalits". Khattar may have moved to the Union cabinet, but his imprint lingers. Saini will have to step out of his mentor's shadow, and fast. ■

RAJASTHAN PAPER LEAKS

A Wide Web of Deceit

By Rohit Parihar

At a time when leaks and lapses have disrupted four national competitive exams, putting the future of over 3.6 million students in jeopardy, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) regime in Rajasthan is grappling with a mammoth legacy problem on that front. Nearly every government job advertised and filled over the past decade has come under scrutiny for leaked question papers, dummy candidates, fake degrees and forged certificates. More and more skeletons are tumbling out of the closet as the probe picks up pace.

Ahead of the assembly election last year, the BJP had promised to crack the whip against all those indulging in unfair means in recruitment exams conducted during the then Ashok Gehlot-led Congress regime. Soon after coming to power in December, Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma tasked Rajasthan Police's Special Operations Group (SOG) with carrying out a thorough investigation into all such cases. Last month, the state government ordered a review of the selection records of some 125,000 government employees recruited during Gehlot's tenure. But the June 23 arrest of a lynchpin—Tulsa Ram, 57, husband of an additional superintendent of police—exposed a deeper nexus stretching back to at least 2012, putting 18 examinations under a cloud for leaks alone.

A week later, the police confirmed the leak of the 2022 forest guard exam paper. It suspected similar issues with the Rajasthan Eligibility Exam for Teachers 2022 even as the district education officers of Banswara and Jalore were sacked for alleged supervisory negligence.



IN ACTION CM Bhajan Lal Sharma has cracked the whip against irregularities in recruitments

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